



neighbours

BATTLE FOR BURMA

What started out as a protest against high prices has transformed into a movement that could unseat the junta

REUTERS

■ By Larry Jagan in Bangkok

The battle for Burma (Myanmar) is underway between the country's two main institutions—the military and the Buddhist monks. Over 200 people, including a dozen monks, died following a violent crackdown by the country's ruling junta against massive protest marches across the country over the past eight weeks. This has been dubbed the saffron revolt as thousands of Buddhist monks, clad in saffron robes, have been leading the demonstrations.

In recent weeks, what were originally protest marches against rising food and fuel prices have taken the form of a serious movement for political change. "Getting rid of the evil generals is now the only solution for the country," said a senior monk over the phone in Rangoon (Yangon). The regime's response to the monks' continued defiance has been brutal,

with police and soldiers wielding batons and flaying the monks as they gathered at the famous Shwedagon Pagoda in central Yangon on September 26. "The monks were beaten up with the butts of rifles, as the soldiers moved in to disperse the crowd that had gathered at the temple," an eyewitness said. One monk was beaten to death.

Myanmar's rulers have only one answer when they are challenged—brutal repression. Thousands of people have been detained, according to diplomatic sources in Yangon. Every night hundreds of pro-democracy supporters are picked up and whisked away in trucks. "Many opposition activists and monks are in hiding, fearing for their lives," a resident in Yangon said. Many key opposition figures, including many actors, artists and writers have been arrested. All the leading members of Aung San Suu Kyi's pro-democracy

DEFIANT: A monk facing soldiers on the streets of Yangon

party, the National League for Democracy, have also been jailed.

More than a thousand monks from monasteries and temples in Yangon have been taken into custody. They have been shackled together and held in makeshift detention centres. The country's again in a state of fear after a few euphoric weeks of protests. Heavily-armed soldiers are patrolling the streets of the main cities and are also guarding the main monasteries to prevent the monks from resuming their street protests.

These demonstrations are the first real challenge to the country's military rulers in more than 19 years. Myanmar's military leaders are the same army commanders who had seized power in a bloody coup in September 1988 and brutally suppressed protest rallies, killing more than 3,000 people. The junta has ruled